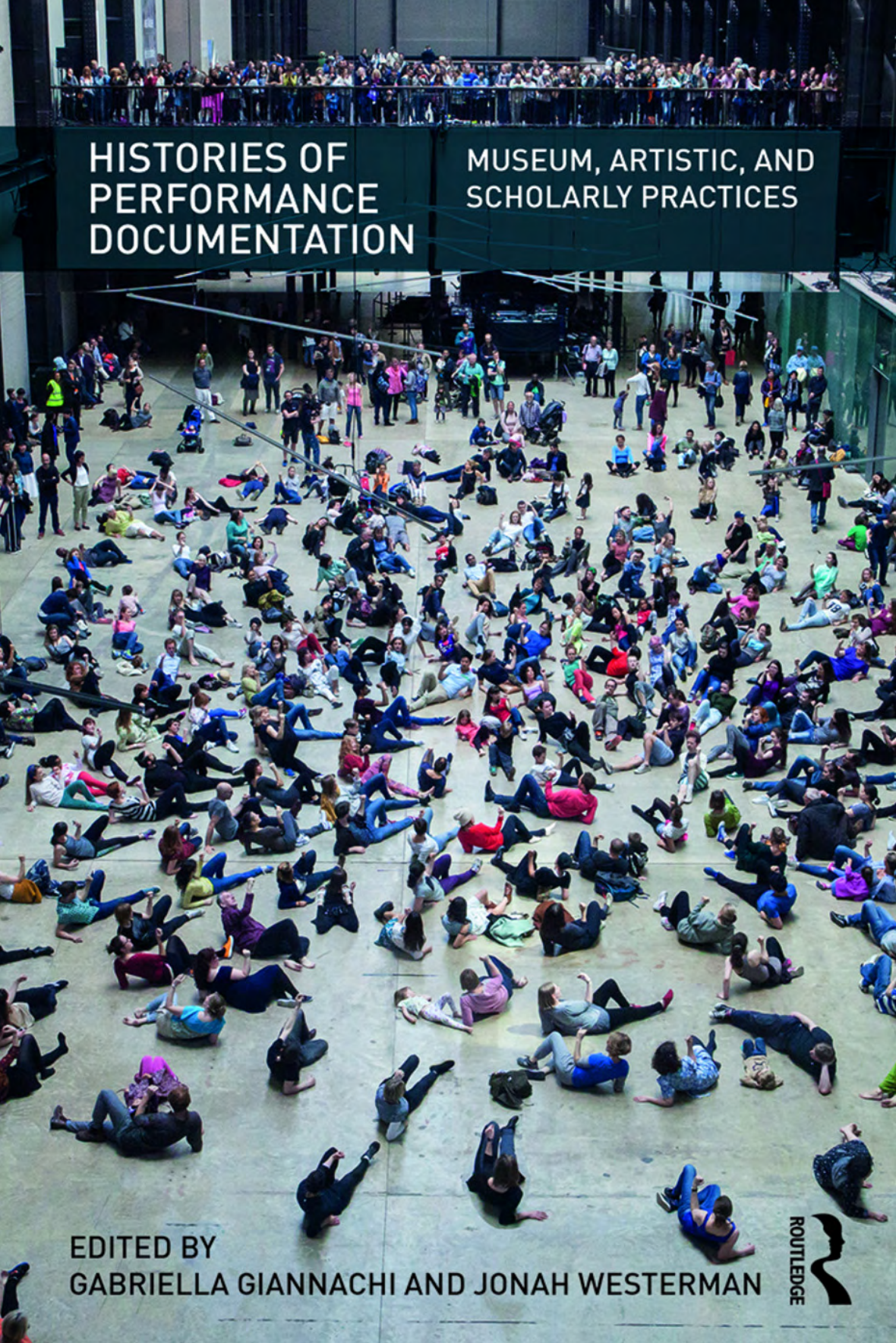

HISTORIES OF PERFORMANCE DOCUMENTATION
MUSEUM, ARTISTIC, AND SCHOLARLY PRACTICES
EDITED BY
GABRIELLA GIANNACHI AND JONAH WESTERMAN
ROUTLEDGE

HISTORIES OF PERFORMANCE DOCUMENTATION

How might we document, curate, collect, and exhibit performance?

Histories of Performance Documentation traces the many ways in which museums have approached performance works from the 1960s onwards. Considering the unique challenges of documenting live events, including hybrid and interactive arts, games, virtual and mixed reality performance, this collection investigates the burgeoning role of the performative in museum displays, and examines a number of interdisciplinary documentation practices that have influenced the field of performance documentation.

Gabriella Giannachi and Jonah Westerman bring together interviews and essays by leading curators, conservators, artists and scholars from institutions including MoMA, Tate, SFMOMA and the Whitney. Developing from recent approaches that argue that discussions of performance should not be focused purely on the live event, and documentation should not be read solely as a process of retrospection, these chapters build a radical new framework for thinking about the relationship between performance and its documentation—and how documentation might shape ideas of what constitutes performance in the first place.

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Museum, Artistic, and Scholarly Practices

Edited by Gabriella Giannachi and Jonah Westerman

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PART I

Interviews



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1

MUSEUM OF MODERN ART, NEW YORK

Stuart Comer, Chief Curator in the Department of Media and Performance Art; Michelle Elligott, Chief of Archives; and Ana Janevski, Associate Curator in the Department of Media and Performance Art

In conversation with Jonah Westerman, April 2015

What is the earliest presence of performance at MoMA?

Michelle Elligott: At the museum's inception, Alfred Barr, the founding director, wanted to include not just painting, sculpture, prints, drawings, but also film, typography, design, theater arts, etc. The museum's first brochure, which he wrote, was basically a mission statement. To me, this is the DNA of the institution. So, as he annotated by hand in his copy of the brochure, we had drawings and prints in 1929; architecture came along in 1932; photography in 1932; industrial design in 1934; film in 1935; and last but not least, theater and dance in 1940. In 1939, Lincoln Kirstein donated his personal archive, mostly about the history of dance, to MoMA, and that created our dance archive. By 1944, the dance archive was promoted, and it was given the status of a full curatorial department. That only lasted for four years, until 1948, but MoMA had a curatorial department called the Department of Dance and Theater Design even at that time. They were collecting items such as photographs of Isadora Duncan; watercolors of her dancing; photographs of Martha Graham; even a whole collection of American Minstrel performances. Additionally, in the 1940s, the museum did all sorts of radical programming with what we might now call performative elements. As early as 1941, we mounted an exhibition of American Indian Art. Native Americans were invited to create a sand painting in the galleries while museum visitors looked on. During World War II, the museum undertook programming in support of the war effort, and we held an exhibition of a diorama of battle troops, on the floor, and there was a ramp that people would ascend to gaze down upon the museum staff repositioning the ships to reflect the current progress of the battle. Because of the 1939 New York World's Fair, this participatory activation of the museum space was very much in the air.

Ana Janevski: The founding idea of the museum was that MoMA should encompass all arts, e.g. film, architecture, photography, painting, sculpture, including theater and dance. This inclusive definition of modern included for a short period a dedicated department for Theater and Dance. Afterwards, artists were invited to participate in different events or even exhibitions. In 1960, Jean Tinguely designed a self-destroying assemblage *Homage to New York*, with help from Bell Labs scientist Billy Kluver, which performed in MoMA's Sculpture Garden. In 1969–1970, Franz Erhard Walther's *First Work Set* (1963–1969) was activated in the museum's lobby as part of the revolutionary exhibition *Spaces*. Performance and dance as live artworks in the museum happened later. Artists like Yayoi Kusama or Guerrilla Art Action Group used performance as a subversive element in the 1960s and 1970s. This ran concurrently to what was happening within the Summer Garden program, almost peripherally, and included different kinds of events—music, dance, and performance by artists like Simone Forti, Steve Paxton, John Cage, and Marta Minujin. MoMA photographers documented some of these, and the documentations are in MoMA's archives. Peter Moore also documented them. You start to wonder: What belongs in the archive? What's the documentation? Does this kind of documentation have a market value? Where should it sit? We are still discussing what this documentation is in relation to the subjects' practice and to the status of photographers as producers.

How do you begin to work through those issues? Is it just that every case is different?

Ana Janevski: Yes, every case is definitely different, there is not one protocol or template, and sometimes it goes beyond documentation. Take the Simone Forti *Dance Constructions* that MoMA has recently acquired. *Dance Constructions* are set dances based around ordinary movement, chance, and simple objects like rope and plywood boards. MoMA acquired the rights to perform the dances and a set of instructions, which we developed over the course of two years. The resulting constellation of materials—ranging from teaching videos to sketches, historical photos, notebooks, and recorded interviews—extensively document previously performed versions and, crucially, offer precise instructions for future dancers. In addition, we would like to organize workshops with groups of dancers and teachers to communicate the dances to new generations of performers and participants. So far there are only a few dancers, Sarah Swenson and Claire Filmon among them, who can teach the *Dance Constructions*. It is about a kind of preservation carried through person-to-person, a set of instructions, a network of conversations and relationships.

Another example in terms of presentation of the work is James Lee Byar's *1001 Mile Paper*, which is a performable sculpture that Lucinda Childs performed in 1965 at the Carnegie. There are written instructions and James Lee Byars instructed her one afternoon. The work had never been shown, never been performed again. As it is part of the MoMA collection, we invited Lucinda to look at an exhibition

copy of the work. It was not possible to manipulate the work, and we did not want her to redo the same work. In the end, she instructed her dancer and followed James Lee Byars's instructions, which just said: make a square, make a circle, make whatever you want, so just interpret the score itself in order to do it. We have many examples of works like this, and there is some kind of institutional responsibility to display them, which is challenging and opens a space for creativity in terms of documentation, preservation, conservation, and transmission.

How has the institution understood that responsibility over the years? The word 'performance' was only added to your department's title in 2009—before that it was the Department of Media, right?

Ana Janevski: Right. The Department of Media was established in 2006, by Klaus Biesenbach, and it changed its name to Media and Performance Art Department in 2009, to better reflect the department's exhibition and acquisition strategy in collecting, displaying, and preserving time-based art. Together with Sabine Breitweiser, who succeeded Biesenbach as a chief curator in 2010 until 2012, and now with Stuart Comer, we have been paying close attention to artists working across media, from performance to moving image, and all of the many permutations in between, and the way they reshape artistic practices, both contemporary and historical. As I mentioned before, historical performances, they often pose important questions in terms of their legacy, permanence, or assimilation into the existing institutional context. There are differences in how artists deal with history, and the institution should remain pliable to accept that for an 'intellectual gift'. As much as the term performance is often under discussion and it encompasses many diverse art forms, it is sure that live art has an impact on the institution. It alters the time-space coordinates of the exhibition apparatus, it shifts the relationship with the public, it brings another idea of authorship, it challenges the established economy, and it exposes the museum's human infrastructure and relationships. Working in a Department of Media and Performance Art, and in a relatively young department compared to the others within the museum, my colleagues and I are facing those issues on a daily basis.

Stuart Comer: For a long time, I have not seen a hierarchy between a work and the archival document, particularly in performance-related work. Is a photograph an archival index or an artwork? I would prefer to keep that rule totally indeterminate and let it be free and circulate throughout all kinds of platforms, exhibitions, publications, websites, films. Photography is very promiscuous, and so is performance, and so is film. I would not want to ring-fence them too much. We do, however, need to identify what value they have in terms of constructing narratives that are useful to positioning time-based arts centrally in the history of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. I do not actually see a radical difference in terms of the indexicality of a photograph of a dance or a performance, versus a Jackson Pollock painting or any other number of ways that movements are traced and

recorded. But we ascribe a very different set of values to all of those different kinds of images, even though they all bear a direct relationship to direct action. I think the performativity of images now, particularly photographic and filmic images, is so rampant, and so fluid and exciting, and I think that will also change, particularly for museums, for publishers, for magazines, etc., as we go further and further into an online world. People like Charles Atlas or Babette Mangolte, who were conventionally seen as documentarians, are now seen emphatically as artists. Those films and videos and photographs now have a very different status and function in the art world. And so that raises a whole other set of issues, like, can they be accessioned or made part of a Collection with a capital C? Should they be? Would that give them more *gravitas* or would it inhibit their use? Because the moment something like that becomes part of a collection, it becomes subject to nine-month loan request deadlines, and that arguably inhibits its ability to enter the world. Whereas if it is part of the archive, anybody can see or hire it. So, I am very interested about just how the museological structures that have always regulated these things can be questioned and changed, and just create more and different kinds of access.

Very practically, then, in terms of the museum's own bureaucratic structures, what is the difference between an object's being a document of an artwork or being an artwork in its own right?

Stuart Comer: Sol LeWitt's *Wall Drawing* is as much a performance as is a Dada cabaret. That moment in conceptual art was a watershed moment for performance, especially in New York. It shows how an image can be an archival thought, it can be an action, it can occupy different registers of time. The same work takes multiple forms throughout its history. A Babette Mangolte photograph can be very fluid in terms of whether it stands on its own as an image, or as a document of a particular moment in time—whether it is seen as a means of illustrating, for lack of a better word, a dance. It is going to have different kinds of use value, depending on the context of presentation. She and Charles Atlas were particularly visually articulate about how to shoot performance and dance. It does transcend mere documentation. It was a very heavily researched, very thought-through dialogue with the artists who were performing, particularly around the Judson period. It went beyond intermedial, it was just a really fluid moment when the boundaries were totally being dissolved. So why would you want to fix one value on any of those images? At the Tate, Catherine [Wood] and I were working separately as the curator of film and the curator of performance, but we were working together on a number of projects, and we saw a lot of value in thinking about performance through its mediation, because we work in a museum. I think the infrastructure of every single museum is still entirely based on paintings and objects. In terms of how the registers are constructed, in terms of how art handling is organized, in terms of how exhibition schedules are organized—generally in three- and four-month blocks, rather than like a two-week festival, marketing as well, just all of the different systems in museums are still largely organized around things that

are not actions or events, but things that are circulated. So the more that these images that may be part of the archive become part of that system, the more museums need to challenge them, but also be responsible to them. So there is a kind of paradox, I guess. The other thing I've been interested in for a while, and I have not really had time yet, is to really focus on the audience as an archive. I think the encounter with the work and how that is articulated and documented through an audience experience is really important, and, certainly in the area of social media, it takes on different possibilities. I know Rhizome recently started a project on how to archive social media as well, and I think this is something a lot of museums will start to take seriously. There has been a lot of academic writing about the importance of gossip as an alternative historical record, and I think social media is critically important. Its intentions may be diametrically opposed to the artist's intentions, or to the curatorial intentions of a project, but I think it's still a pretty accurate capture of how people encounter something. Capitalism is about movement, it's about circulation. Our museums are beginning to reflect that logic much more. I remember when I first started at Tate and the head of the collection said if it was on a wall, and it moved, then it wasn't art. Now, we're defining so many art forms by their ability to change over time.

Michelle Elligott: For me as an archivist and art historian, everything is about context, it is about the package. A single item might be important and compelling, but it is really meaningless when you rip it outside of that sort of wrapper. It is really about the systems that these documents communicate and travel within. To me, that is where the history is made and where it resides. And so, in response to requests to transfer items out of the archives into the MoMA collection, I reiterate: let's be careful we don't miss the point here, because then we're going to lose all of this really important context. Think of the Van Abbemuseum documentation center, or the Reina Sofía—Manolo Borja-Villel's conceptualization of the museum space as the archives of the commons, the idea of reclassifying the museum collection when possible, erasing the classification of 'work of art', and reclassifying everything as archival. From what I understand, Whitechapel Gallery, Van Abbe, and Reina Sofía are really using the archives to think about how objects mean different things over time, and how this affects their mission. I am interested in the life of objects, and the life of ideas, and I think the archives, the documents held there, can help stimulate those dialogues. As far as the archives of the future, over the last couple of years, I have been investigating and attempting to establish an electronic records archive. We just selected a platform, and we will transfer all the letters, the emails, the checklists—all of those documents that are now being born and managed digitally. First, we need to aggregate these materials, because no one is taking care of that yet, and they are at risk of just disappearing if a staff member leaves the museum or they get misplaced. Once we get that under control, then I would like to start accessioning certain materials, such as audio, video, and photographic documentation of museum events and performances, from

the digital asset management system, or DAM. The DAM is an internal access vehicle, but it is not a preservation tool. The electronic archive system that we are using helps us automate the preservation. So, going forward, that will be a repository for permanent records. Incidentally, it is the same system employed by the UK National Archives. With our mission, research and education go hand in hand, and the archive plays into both of those. MoMA was integral to creation of the historiography of twentieth-century art. The archive is key for that understanding, as well as for tracing the future evolution of art and society.

2

WHITNEY MUSEUM OF AMERICAN ART, NEW YORK

Jay Sanders, Engell Speyer Family Curator and Curator of Performance

In conversation with Jonah Westerman, April 2015

How did performance come into view for you at the Whitney Museum?

I was first invited to be a part of the Whitney by curator Elisabeth Sussman who asked me to co-organize the 2012 Whitney Biennial. In our initial research, which involved intensely interrogating how the museum's spaces could be used, we saw the Whitney's largest gallery floor as a potential site for performance. In 2011, a large Paul Thek exhibition had just come down and we were looking at the gallery with all its temporary walls gone, just prior to the next show being constructed. It was an epiphany for us, and a few of the artists who also saw it, to consider working with that entire open space. Our decision to use the gallery for performance was less about the apparatus of the museum, or even the structure of the biennial, than about the intrinsic qualities of the space itself. As it turns out, the history of staging performances on the Whitney's open gallery floors in between exhibitions of painting and sculpture goes back to the 1960s, during the first years of the Whitney in the Marcel Breuer-designed building uptown. Breuer's architecture allowed for loft-like, non-dressed up spaces—the kind that artists such as Trisha Brown, Yvonne Rainer, Lucinda Childs, Deborah Hay, Richard Foreman, and Steve Paxton, who did projects there, were already using downtown. Curators Marcia Tucker and James Monte were aware of what was happening in alternative spaces and lofts in the late 1960s and early 1970s, and realized that they could offer comparable conditions for performance by clearing the museum's galleries of their objects and walls.

At that same time, the Whitney was also staging live arts in the direct vicinity of plastic arts. There was a series called the *Composers' Showcase*, which began in 1968 and was organized by independent curator Charles Schwartz. Schwartz invited Ornette Coleman, John Cage, Meredith Monk, and countless others to

present concerts in the galleries. So you could see Mary Lou Williams and the Cecil Taylor Unit or Sun Ra's Arkestra amidst contemporary visual art on the walls. There was also an exhibition of Harry Partch's invented instruments that included a concert of them being played. Poets too, such as John Ashbery, Diane Wakoski, Allen Ginsburg, Anne Waldman, David Antin, and others presented new work within the galleries at the Whitney. On a very different note, in 1970, artist Robert Morris turned the museum into a massive active construction site. The Whitney invited him to mount a mid-career survey, but instead he loaded in literally tons of wooden beams, concrete, and steel. The show opened the day the first truck started to unload, and continued from there. The choreographer Yvonne Rainer had seen another of Morris's large-scale process pieces, *Continuous Project Altered Daily*, the year before. She appropriated that title for her own work, presenting a performance at the museum the week before Morris's show opened. In this important durational dance piece, she expanded the frame of a dance by including learning, rehearsal, and an unfolding structural form as part of the visible experience, and emulated what she saw happening within contemporary sculpture, looking, for example, at how gravity was working between objects and people.

One year earlier, in 1969, the Whitney presented the intermedia exhibition *Anti-Illusion: Procedures/Materials*, a watershed show that introduced the public to work that was fundamentally about process. Steve Reich performed *Pendulum Music* in the gallery, Philip Glass's ensemble gave a concert, Michael Snow screened his structuralist films, and installations such as Bruce Nauman's interactive *Performance Corridor* (1969) were on view. Some of the artworks were site-specifically created and others changed forms over the course of the exhibition. In 1974, curator John Hanhardt joined the Whitney and developed a film and video cinematheque on the second floor of the Breuer. Hanhardt presented a wide range of experimental and expanded cinema, and his highly responsive program championed multicultural and feminist work. He also organized live performances: at the time of Nam June Paik's retrospective, Hanhardt presented a concurrent Fluxus performance series. With regard to downtown performance art, it was Marcia Tucker and a few others at the Whitney who tracked emerging practices in the 1970s in real time. Tucker organized a festival called *Four Evenings, Four Days* (1976), which featured artists like Julia Heyward, Laurie Anderson, Adrian Piper, Jared Bark, Stuart Sherman, and Michael Smith, most making their museum debuts. As performance art was burgeoning in New York, through these kinds of efforts, it entered into the museum.

How did you work with the documentation of these histories for Rituals of Rented Island: Object Theater, Loft Performance, and the New Psychodrama—Manhattan, 1970–1980 *(2013–2014)?*

My colleague Greta Hartenstein and I had to do a great deal of primary research because many of those artists did not have a clear written history. You would see

one photo somewhere, or read a review, or hear a recollection from someone from that era, and then try to work out what this stratum of documentation constituted. We started by generating an artist list, delineating in part a social network, but also tracing artistic tenets. We were committed to presenting artists like Julia Heyward and Jill Kroesen even if we had no idea whether any traces of their work—videotapes, props, ephemera—still existed. No matter how fleeting the actual performances were, I wanted to really understand the intrinsic vision of the artist and the character of the work, and then conjure a means of displaying it with whatever we could find, in collaboration with the artist whenever possible. That was the ground rule of that show, but the particularities were different for each case. For example, with Stuart Sherman, I had heard of his work many years earlier from playwright Richard Foreman and LA artist Mike Kelley. In books that document the history of experimental theater or performance art, he was only occasionally mentioned in passing. In going back and systematically reading old issues of *The Drama Review*, *Art-Rite*, *Soho Weekly News*, *Avalanche*, *PAJ*, and other publications, we began to chart the course of his work and how it was received. In this way, you could start to see who performed where—for example, who was included in *Four Evenings, Four Days*—and build a history of these appearances in an archival way. In the case of artist Ralston Farina, he was willfully cryptic and did not leave traces of his work. Nearly everything one might learn about him was word of mouth via a wide range of artists who saw him first-hand. A few months before the exhibition opened, thanks to J. Hoberman, we got in touch with two of Farina's close high school friends who actually had all his stuff. We had already closed our checklist, and these guys basically FedExed everything he had saved surrounding his live performances. With artist Jack Smith, too, there was no primary document of his performances. What we had was the gloss that he himself created: hand-drawn flyers, promotional headshots, scripts and sketches, notes for staging, props, and photos. I thought that one could find core qualities in these remaining materials he so carefully designed. In the 1970s, many artists were performatively embodying media systems and modes of entertainment, and we can read into what they were doing, even though we were not there. I think, somehow, you still get a lot of information and beauty from the residue of that work.

In thinking about earlier museum exhibitions, *Out of Actions: Between Performance and the Object* (Museum of Contemporary Art, Los Angeles, 1998) was an incredibly important, broadly inclusive survey that drew a global map of so many important practices. In its manifestation, it privileged visual artists and the art object, whether that be a painting made through action, a sculpture that acted as a performance prop, or a film of a live event. Alternatively, with *Rituals of Rented Island*, the artists included came not only from visual art backgrounds but also via dance, theater, music, and poetry. There was often no durable artifact from their performances. I had questions about the value of the documentation, and wondered how, and in what forms, it could be read, and how our reading of the material changes over time. What can we ascertain from displaying these

ephemeral, time-based, highly contingent art practices within the confines of an art museum and a curatorial precept? Any looking back at live work, by the artist or even more so by curators and scholars, changes its meaning in some way.

How has the curation of performance at the Whitney changed over time?

I am really interested in this ongoing question of how museums produce and exhibit live work, and I think, in some ways, that history can reflect how different art forms were interacting at different times. As we've been discussing, there was an important point beginning in the 1960s when—though still hierarchical in terms of relative opportunity and support—performance, dance, and music became integral to the identity and program of the Whitney through the presentation of new work. But then there is also this parallel history of how a museum with a permanent collection and the ability to craft art historical narratives defines and configures objects and artistic practices in retrospect. I am interested in these tensions—how museums embrace the responsibility to produce and reflect the contemporary, and then how other systems and value judgments shape what is deemed valuable, holdable, and legible within exhibitions and collections. *Rituals of Rented Island* was a way to put forth this group of artists, many of whom were marginalized because their work did not have the ability to live on beyond its own live manifestation, or it was actively conceived in opposition to that sense of value. Through showing this untold art history, it was also for me very much about bringing it to the present. I began seeing that current artists were increasingly setting aside concerns over clear definitions of object versus action, solidity or timelessness, and were instead couching work within interactive, contingent, and theatrical frames. So these artists of the 1970s felt like very urgent exemplars that could inform and articulate the present. The ways we approached displaying this work in museum galleries straddled a fundamental tension: if the show appeared museological, it should simultaneously reveal itself to be a series of fantasies and approximations reflecting vanished realities.

To get back to the Whitney's history, as performance moved into the 1980s and 1990s, it reflected the artistic currents of the time. The radical convergence of performance and visual art of the 1960s and 1970s was less prevalent during this period. As the Whitney forged temporary corporate partnerships to create branch museums in New York City and its surrounding area, much of the Whitney's performance programming began to migrate to these new spaces. With the opening of the Whitney Museum of American Art at Philip Morris (subsequently Altria), located on Park Avenue and 42nd Street in a large glass-walled lobby atrium, the Whitney found a major long-term collaborator and supporter for its live art program. From 1984 to the mid-2000s, there was a rich and diverse performance program, where artists were interacting both with the context of the Whitney Museum and notably with the bustle of street-level midtown Manhattan. Adjunct curators such as Jeanette Vuocolo and Boo Froebel programmed hundreds of performances of music, theater, and dance by artists such as Butch Morris, Joan Jonas,

John Zorn, Olu Dara, Wendy Perron, the Wooster Group, Christian Marclay, Savion Glover, DJ Olive, Stephen Vitiello, Dean Moss, Cynthia Hopkins, Phil Kline, Liza Jessie Peterson, Ishmael Houston-Jones, and many others. Whitney Biennials, curatorial snapshots of their time, have also been increasingly important to this history. In the 1993 Biennial, for example, Dancenoise, Marga Gomez, John Kelly, James Luna, Robbie McCauley, and Mac Wellman were showcased at Philip Morris.

Before Altria closed in 2008, the Whitney had started to reintegrate its performance program uptown to create a more direct dialogue between performance and the visual arts within the core of the institution. In 2006, Limor Tomer, the then-adjunct curator for performing arts, launched *Whitney Live*, an ongoing series of free Friday night music, dance, and performance events in the museum's lower gallery, sculpture court, and film and video gallery. The inaugural event, *Steve Reich @ the Whitney*, celebrated the composer's 70th birthday with a wide array of activities that were given substantial museum space and blurred the lines between installation and performance. *Whitney Live* presented both emerging performers and key restagings of historical work. As part of the exhibition *Off the Wall* (2010), choreographer Trisha Brown was invited to restage her infamous *Walking on the Walls*, first performed at the Whitney in 1971, as well as *Man Walking Down the Side of a Building* on the exterior of the museum's façade. So too, composer, singer, and multidisciplinary artist Meredith Monk presented a day-long marathon of performances from her influential career.

As we open the Whitney's new building downtown, one central discussion is how artists will inevitably inscribe new histories into its blank slate. We were eager to see this start as soon as possible. One artist in the 2014 Biennial, Yve Laris Cohen, conceived his choreographic project to directly play between the exhibition space in the Breuer, where the biennial was on view, and the theater in the new building as it was still under construction. And last winter (2014), before we had our Certificate of Occupancy, we organized a series of performances, 'rumors' we called them, for small invited audiences. Everyone still had to wear hard hats. The composer and saxophonist Matana Roberts improvised throughout the building, percussionist Glenn Kotche gave a concert on the Whitney's vast open 5th floor gallery, and Carolee Schneemann created a holiday environment with thousands of Christmas lights in which she performed. As we plan our numerous opening events to inaugurate the Whitney's new home, performance artists are playing a central role. Tomorrow night at our opening for artists, John Cale and Tony Conrad will collaborate for the first time in 50 years, presenting a large-scale outdoor live music and film event that addresses the legacy of minimalism. We commissioned the Wooster Group to stage a 'ribbon-cutting ceremony' next week, and there will be a large day-long block party with performance artists both designing booths and performing on an outdoor stage. Artist Andrea Geyer is working with our Education Department to reflect on the founding of the museum by Gertrude Vanderbilt Whitney through a series of performative engagements in the permanent collection galleries.

With the new building, we have a dedicated theater for the first time in the museum's history. There is also infrastructure that accommodates a wide range of activities within the galleries themselves—wooden floors with neoprene padding beneath them, power and data running throughout the exhibition spaces. We also have numerous outdoor terraces that have been conceived of with live art in mind. Building on the Whitney's own history, we are still interested in upturning the expected use of spaces. We want to give artists exciting spaces to work in.

Given how important the Whitney's own history has been to your own practice, how do you think about self-historicizing, about creating an archive of the current moment?

That's a timely question. In a very literal way, I can mention a new project by Yuji Agematsu, a Japanese-American artist who, for decades, has collected the detritus that constitutes New York City. Over the past year, he has been photographing the Meatpacking District—documenting the Whitney's construction, the High Line, and the vast changes that have been occurring in the neighborhood in his own highly particular and idiosyncratic manner. The first project in our new theater will be an environment of looping slide projections that he is creating. And our first year of performance programming has a strong dialogue with the museum's inaugural collection exhibition, *America Is Hard to See*. There will be retrospectives of the composer Conlon Nancarrow, downtown performance legends Dancenoise, and musician and performance pioneer Takehisa Kosugi.

In looking back at projects here, one realizes that so much happens logistically in the dynamic between the artist and curator, and then in how the curator navigates the project through the institution. Those machinations are difficult to archive, and the gaps in knowledge that inevitably occur have given me ideas about how to leave more of a trace. Performances will have more prominence on our website, more like exhibitions, so their centrality and importance to what we do as a whole can be more clearly manifested. And of course, for each new performance, we photograph and videorecord the work, and take into consideration the artists' input and methodology toward the afterlife of their work, which at times suggests other forms of documentation. That's all uniquely specific project by project. It is interesting how museum systems are still strongly tied to the exhibition model. I am working on a project with Laura Poitras, the filmmaker who's most known for her movie about Edward Snowden, *Citizenfour*. Before Snowden had contacted her, she had been talking about trying to experiment outside of single-channel filmmaking to allow for different kinds of experiences. She is going to have an exhibition in February 2016 on the Whitney's top floor that reveals this new approach. We are going to black out the skylights and she will make a series of new media installations. We do not know what she is making; we do not know if she is doing performance, because everything is going to be new work. But one can see that the way the museum system works—with the registrars, the art handling, the wall builders, the publication team—that even though nothing about the artwork is known, you feel like you are on a conveyor

belt moving the right way within the institution. And with performance, you still at times feel like you are running the wrong way on the conveyor belt, producing projects within a museum. It is much easier to mount an exhibition, no matter how unconventional it is, than to make performances. There is still a learning curve about performance as, inevitably, it challenges every conceivable system in a museum. But maybe that is one inherent role performance always plays, both in art history and institutional histories.

Works cited

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